

ROMAN FORTIFICATION

ARBEIA FORT

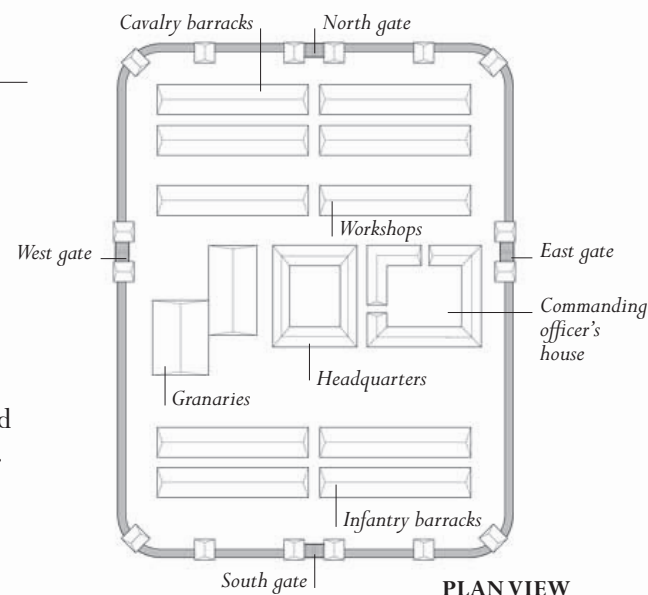
The Roman army built the ancient world's greatest fortifications. Legionaries were more like combat engineers than ordinary soldiers, being trained in construction as well as the art of battle.

On campaign, a legion made a wooden camp, surrounded by an earth rampart, at every stop. Permanent forts were initially also made of wood and earth, but later ones, like the reconstructed Arbeia, in northeast England, were stone-built. Used as barracks, administrative centres, and supply depots, they maintained a military presence in potentially hostile territory.

Outposts of Roman civilization, the forts made no concessions to local climates or cultures, displaying similar features across

the empire. Living conditions were basic and cramped – units of eight soldiers called *contubernia*, or “tent groups”, shared small, two-roomed suites in the barracks. However, with heated bathhouses and latrines cleaned by running water, hygiene standards were relatively high.

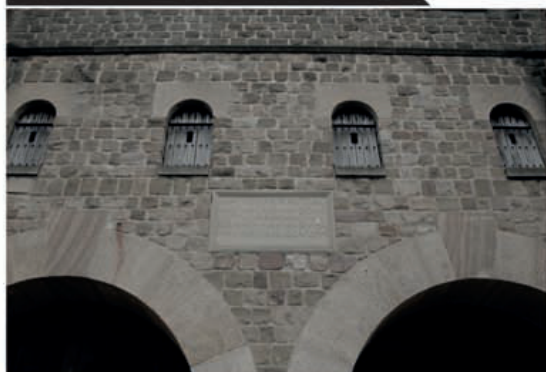
Arbeia was a small fort, housing about 600 auxiliary troops, both infantry and cavalry. Built in the 2nd century CE, it was a major supply centre for the troops on Hadrian's Wall to the north.



▲ LAYOUT OF A ROMAN FORT

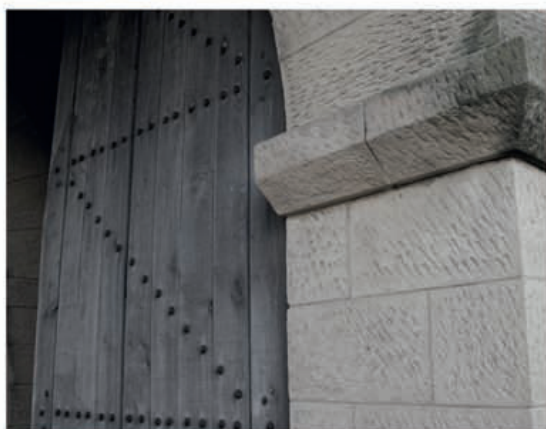
Large or small, most Roman forts were built to a similar plan, with barracks for cavalry and infantry, workshops, granaries, and a separate headquarters.

FORT ENTRANCE



▲ GATEHOUSE PLAQUE

The plaque states that the fort was built by Legio VI Victrix under Sextus Calpurnius Agricola, governor of Britain (c.163–66CE).



▲ DOORS AND WALLS

Solid stone walls and thick wooden doors would have kept out the bands of tribal fighters who occasionally carried out raids in Roman Britain.

► GATEHOUSE

Although the twin towers of Arbeia's gatehouse are imposing, they are smaller than those at some other Roman forts and city walls.

